

Digital Humanities Project Proposal

Address all questions and describe how creative and powerful your finalized work will be. You may include images or datasets if necessary. There is no limit to the length. Your proposal and finalized outcome will be graded based on how **effective** and **compelling** they are.

This proposal must be submitted as part of your finalized assignment packet (**due on Friday, June 12**).

1. What is the focus of your project, and what questions are you seeking to explore?

My project studies the Bank of England's crisis access network from 1847 to 1997. The main question is whether the Bank managed financial stress through an open public market, or through a narrow group of recognised City institutions such as bill brokers, discount houses, merchant banks, and clearing banks.

The project also asks three smaller questions. Did a stable inner circle appear near the Bank during Victorian crises? Did the 1866 transatlantic telegraph weaken that advantage by making information faster? Did the same access structure survive into the twentieth century in a different institutional form?

The working argument is that British finance became modern, but not simply open. Price information moved faster over time, but access to the Bank remained mediated through recognised financial actors until the 1997 reform.

2. What sources and data is your work based on, whether physical, digital, or a combination of both?

The project is based on a mix of archival, digitised, and processed historical sources, and each one is used for a specific job. The central financial source is the Bank of England lender-of-last-resort transaction data discussed by Anson, Bholat, Kang and Thomas (2017). It records counterparty names, dates, and amounts for the Bank's crisis lending in the 1847, 1857, 1866 and 1914 crises, and I use it to identify which firms reached the Bank's discount window, to classify them into actor types, and to measure which firms recur across crises.

For timing, I use the Bank of England's daily Bank Rate from A Millennium of Macroeconomic Data, which runs continuously from 1833 and acts as the common market-facing stress clock for every crisis. To date when each crisis became public I use digitised newspapers from the HMD material and the Hansard parliamentary record, and to date when it became visible to the specialist financial world I use The Bankers' Magazine. Comparing these dates is what produces the lead time between insider visibility and the public rupture.

Several further sources support the institutional and market comparison. The Yale Investor's Monthly Manual provides monthly listed-financial-sector prices, used to test whether the market repriced before the public rupture. A reconstruction of 1906 sterling bills by Accominotti, Lucena-Piquero and Ugolini supplies counts of drawers, acceptors and discounters, used to measure the prewar access funnel. Römer's 1931 reconstruction of Bank operations, the Bank of England Quarterly Bulletin

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articles of 1967 and 1978, and the Bank's discount-house database for 1976 to 1996 carry the access structure into the twentieth century. For the 1890 Baring crisis, where no transaction ledger survives, I reconstructed a daily series by transcribing the Bank's handwritten 1890 Daily Account Books with a vision AI model and validating the figures against the daily Bank Rate.

The project also rests on a body of scholarly sources, which I read and checked before use. Bagehot's *Lombard Street* (1873) supplies the classic rule the project tests. Anson, Bholat, Kang and Thomas (2017) and Flandreau and Ugolini (2011) are the closest prior studies of the Bank's crisis ledgers, with the latter reading the 1866 panic through the discount houses and bill brokers. Bordo (1990) and White (2016) frame the emergence of the lender-of-last-resort role and the 1890 Baring rescue. Accominotti, Lucena-Piquero and Ugolini, and Römer, provide the 1906 and 1931 reconstructions. Hoag (2006) and the Richmond Fed document the 1866 telegraph and the collapse of the transatlantic price gap, Amini and Toms (2021) give a precedent for network analysis of the Victorian City, and Gorton and Ordoñez (2014) and Hopkins (1988) supply the framing of crises as information events and of London finance as a relational elite.

3. What methods do you employ to gather, preprocess, and organize your datasets?

The first step was to gather the data and record source provenance. I kept track of where each source came from, what it contains, and what it cannot show. The transaction ledgers were cleaned and grouped by counterparty type. The Bank Rate series was used to create a daily timing signal. Newspaper and periodical sources were searched to identify public and specialist visibility dates.

The analysis then turns these sources into comparable clocks, networks, and scores. I use transaction-ledger analysis to identify who reached the Bank, counterparty classification to group firms by actor type, recurrence analysis to see which institutions appear across crises, lead-time analysis to compare early Bank signals with public rupture dates, and text mining to date public and specialist visibility. I also use concentration and funnel analysis for the 1906 bill market, source-derived actor-flow networks for 1931 and 1973, time-series summaries for the discount-house data, a continuity index to compare periods, and a price-proxy test using Yale market data.

AI tools were used to help create and debug the analysis programs that turn the raw sources into results. These programs clean and tidy the transaction ledgers, the daily Bank Rate, and the macro series into comparable datasets; classify each counterparty into an actor type and resolve duplicate firm names; measure how often firms recur across crises and build the access network, using graph centrality to find the most central firm; compute the lead time between the earliest market signal and the public rupture; text-mine the newspapers and periodicals to date public and specialist visibility; measure the concentration and access funnel of the 1906 bill market; transcribe the handwritten 1890 account books with a vision model and validate the result; build the continuity index; and generate the figures, tables, and the interactive website. I did not treat AI output as evidence, and all historical claims were checked against the datasets and the original readings. A full account of how I used AI is given in the accompanying AI usage statement.

4. What critical reflections do you have regarding the process of compiling and preprocessing your data?

The main difficulty was that the sources were created for different purposes. A Bank ledger records transactions, not motives. A newspaper shows public visibility, not the full public mood. A price index can test broad listed-market movement, but it cannot reveal private profits or the trading of unlisted firms.

This shaped the language of the project. I avoid saying that intermediaries knew a crisis was coming or profited from it. Instead, I measure visibility, timing, positioning, and access. This makes the

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argument more careful. The project can show that stress appeared earlier in market-facing records than in the public rupture, and that access to the Bank passed through recognised actors. It cannot prove private knowledge.

The preprocessing also made source criticism central. Digitised newspapers depend on survival, scanning, and OCR quality. The Bank's own histories are useful for institutional structure, but they are also official self-descriptions. Later twentieth-century data are often aggregate, so they support claims about actor types rather than detailed firm-level behavior.

5. What specific resources will you require to complete your project on time?

To complete the project, I need access to the historical datasets that make the comparison possible. These include the Bank of England lender-of-last-resort transaction data, the daily Bank Rate series, digitised newspapers and periodicals, Hansard, The Bankers' Magazine, Yale Investor's Monthly Manual, bill-market reconstructions, Bank of England institutional histories, and late twentieth-century discount-house data.

I also need analysis tools and code for cleaning, classifying, and comparing these sources. The project uses Python scripts for data cleaning, text searching, lead-time calculation, counterparty classification, recurrence analysis, network construction, continuity scoring, and figure generation. For presentation, I need the LaTeX paper files, generated tables and figures, the source notes, and the website code that turns the results into an interactive digital history project.

6. What strategies will you employ to highlight the key messages or answers in your work?

The final work will have two formats. The detailed paper gives the full argument, source criticism, methods, and evidence for readers who want the complete research. The website presents the same project in a more visual and interactive way. It begins with a simple narrative. A crisis becomes public as a headline, but stress may be visible earlier inside the City of London. The viewer then follows the actors, the sources, the scholarly debate, the crisis timeline, and the main results.

The key message will be shown visually rather than only described in prose. The site uses a crisis timeline, actor networks, lead-time comparisons, the telegraph test, recurrence charts, and a continuity index. The presentation page condenses the project into a four-minute slide format.

The main claim will be stated clearly at the end. The Bank of England's access network changed form, but it did not simply open. From Victorian bill brokers to authorised counterparties, crisis access remained mediated through recognised institutions until 1997.

7. What potential challenges or limitations do you anticipate during the development of your project, and how do you plan to address them?

One challenge is avoiding overclaiming. The sources can show timing, access, and institutional structure, but they cannot show private thoughts or guaranteed profit. I address this by using careful terms such as early signal, market visibility, institutional access, public rupture, and lead time.

A second challenge is uneven evidence across time. Victorian ledgers are more detailed than many twentieth-century sources. Later evidence is often aggregate or based on official accounts. I address this by separating the stronger Victorian information claim from the later access-network claim.

There are also technical limits in the analysis. Newspaper searching depends on OCR quality, survival of issues, and search terms. Name matching is difficult because the same firm can appear in different forms across sources. Actor classification also involves judgement, especially when one institution could act as a merchant bank, bill broker, or acceptance house in different contexts.

The lead-time analysis depends on defining dates for early signal and public rupture. These dates are historically meaningful, but they are not automatic facts in the data. I address this by recording the

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rule used for each date, keeping the source notes visible, and treating results as comparative evidence rather than exact measurement.

Another limitation is that the project cannot observe all private market activity. Some trades, private correspondence, and internal Bank discussions are missing or unavailable. This means the network I reconstruct is a visible access network, not the full hidden world of City finance.

A final challenge is making a financial topic understandable to non-specialists. I address this through short definitions, actor-based storytelling, visual explanations, and source criticism that explains what each dataset can and cannot support.

8. In what ways does your work offer a new perspective on the humanities?

The project offers a humanities perspective by treating financial crises as historical events shaped by actors, institutions, communication systems, and public visibility. It is not only a study of interest rates or banking data. It asks how power and access worked inside British finance, and how that structure changed over time.

The digital part matters because the argument appears only when different kinds of records are linked together. Bank ledgers, rate data, newspapers, price records, bill-market reconstructions, and official histories were not created as one archive. By placing them on one timeline, the project makes a hidden access structure visible.

The new perspective is that modern finance did not simply become more open as information moved faster. The telegraph helped prices move quickly, but access to the Bank remained organised through recognised intermediaries. That distinction between faster information and open access is the main contribution of the project.

This contribution becomes clearer when the project is set beside existing work. The closest studies use the same Bank of England ledgers, but they ask different questions. Anson and colleagues ask whether the Bank followed the classic rule of lending freely in a panic, and Flandreau and Ugolini read a single crisis, 1866, through the discount houses and bill brokers. Network analysis has been used on the Victorian City before, by Amini and Toms on interlocking company directors, and economic historians such as Hoag have shown that the 1866 telegraph made prices travel faster. The pieces existed separately. What this project does is put them on one question, following the same named firms across many crises over a century and a half, turning their recurrence into a network it can measure, and using the telegraph as a test that separates faster prices from open access.

The humanities value of the project is that it tells this through actors rather than abstractions. Instead of scoring an institution against a rule, it follows identifiable firms, from Overend Gurney in the Victorian panics to Union Discount on the Bank's authorised list in 1996, and asks who could reach the centre of British finance in a crisis. Read this way, the story is not that modernity opened finance to everyone. The Victorian inner circle was never abolished. It was carried forward and written into formal rules, so an older world of relationships and privileged access survived inside the language of a modern, rule-based system. The project also stays careful about what it can claim. It measures dated visibility and access, not private knowledge or profit, which keeps it honest about the limits of what historical records can show.